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DADDY HUNGER

The Daddy Hunger Language Guide

Rewriting what we say to our children —
one phrase at a time

Some of the phrases we grew up hearing were meant to build strength. But often, without meaning to, they taught us that pain should be hidden, that men don't matter, and that love is something you earn through silence.

This guide offers a different way to say the same things — words that build strength AND connection, discipline AND safety.

A FREE RESOURCE FROM

Ray Upchurch • Author of The 10 Commandments of Fatherhood

DaddyHunger.org

Many of the phrases below were passed down with good intentions — meant to build toughness, respect, or independence. But some of them, said enough times, quietly teach a child that their feelings are inconvenient, that fathers don't matter, or that love has to be earned through silence. Below is a different way to say the same things.

Language About Men & Fathers

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Girl, I don't need a man.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I don't need a man to complete me, but a good man makes this family stronger.”

Why it matters: Keeps a mother's strength and independence intact without teaching a child that healthy men have no meaningful role in family life.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Men ain't nothing but trouble.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“Some men haven't learned how to show up. That doesn't mean all men are the same.”

Why it matters: Separates disappointment in specific men from a blanket message about manhood itself.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“You're just like your daddy.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I see some of your father in you — let's talk about which parts we want to keep.”

Why it matters: Turns a comparison used as an insult into an honest, guided conversation about identity.

Discipline Language

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Stop crying before I give you something to cry about.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I see you're hurting. Tell me what happened.”

Why it matters: Meets emotion with curiosity instead of threat — teaching a child that pain is safe to express, not something to be punished for.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Because I said so.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“Because I'm responsible for keeping you safe. Let me explain why.”

Why it matters: Keeps the parent's authority while modeling reasoning — something children eventually respect more than raw power.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Man up. / Boys don't cry.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“Feel it, then decide what you're going to do about it.”

Why it matters: Makes room for the feeling before asking for a response — strength without emotional shutdown.

Language About the Relationship Itself

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“I can't wait until you turn 18 and move out.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I can't wait to see who you become — and I want to still be part of that story.”

Why it matters: Reframes parenting from a sentence being served to an ongoing investment in the relationship.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“I'm not your friend, I'm your parent.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I'm your parent first — and I still want to be someone you can talk to.”

Why it matters: Keeps the boundary of authority while leaving the door open for real connection.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“You'll understand when you're older.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“Let me try to explain this in a way that makes sense to you now.”

Why it matters: Respects a child's need to understand rather than dismissing the question altogether.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Children are to be seen and not heard.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“Your voice matters here. I want to hear what you think.”

Why it matters: Teaches a child their inner world is welcome, not an inconvenience — often exactly where “Daddy Hunger” begins.

Language About Mistakes & Failure

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“I'm disappointed in you.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I'm disappointed in this choice, but not in who you are. I know you can do better, and I'll help you get there.”

Why it matters: Separates behavior from identity — names the standard without attaching shame to the child's worth.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“You always mess things up.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“This didn't go the way we wanted — let's figure out what happened.”

Why it matters: Addresses the moment instead of building a permanent identity out of one mistake.

Language About Vulnerability & Manhood

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Real men don't need help.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“Knowing when to ask for help is strength, not weakness.”

Why it matters: Redefines strength to include self-awareness, not just self-sufficiency.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Suck it up.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“It's okay to hurt. Let's work through it together.”

Why it matters: Offers companionship in pain instead of demanding it disappear silently.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Be a man about it.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“Face it honestly. Courage starts with telling the truth.”

Why it matters: Ties courage to honesty instead of turning manhood into another narrow standard to live up to.

Language About Comparison

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Why can't you be like your brother/sister?”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“You don't have to be anyone but yourself — let's talk about what's going on with you.”

Why it matters: Removes the sibling (or cousin) as the measuring stick and refocuses on the actual child in front of you.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Your cousin is doing so much better than you.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I believe in what you're capable of. Let's figure out the next step.”

Why it matters: Replaces comparison with belief and a concrete path forward.

Language About Provision & Success

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“I didn't have a daddy and I turned out fine.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I survived without one — but I don't want you to have to just survive.”

Why it matters: Honors the parent's resilience while raising the bar for the next generation.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“As long as you have a roof over your head, don't complain.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I want to provide for your body and your heart.”

Why it matters: Expands “provision” beyond material needs to emotional presence.

Language About Love & Affection

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“I don't have to say I love you, you know I do.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I love you — and I want you to hear me say it.”

Why it matters: Removes the guesswork; children shouldn't have to infer love from silence.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Actions speak louder than words.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“My actions show it, and I want my words to say it too.”

Why it matters: Affection doesn't have to be either/or — both reinforce the same message.

Language About Trust & Independence

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“You'll thank me later.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“I know this is hard right now — I'm here while you figure it out.”

Why it matters: Stays present in the difficulty instead of deferring connection to some future point.

✗ WE'VE ALL HEARD IT

“Toughen up, the world isn't going to be nice to you.”

★ TRY THIS INSTEAD

“The world will test you — I want home to be the place you can be soft.”

Why it matters: Prepares a child for the world without turning home into another place they have to armor up for.

This guide will keep growing. If a phrase from your own childhood belongs here, we'd love to hear it — visit DaddyHunger.org to share your story.

Published by Daddy Hunger Press

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